TRIHEXYPHENIDYL

Confusion in elderly

Drug-induced parkinsonism

CHEMICAL NAME (RS)-1-cyclohexyl-1-phenyl-3-(piperidin-1-yl)propan-1-ol (hydrochloride); also benzhexol

CLASS Centrally acting antimuscarinic (antiparkinsonian)

TRADE NAMES Artane · Pacitane · Benzhexol · Parkin

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Drug-induced extrapyramidal symptoms (parkinsonism, dystonia) from antipsychotics (not tardive dyskinesia).
- Parkinson's disease; tremor-predominant in younger patients.
- Dystonia (high doses, specialist).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** with or after food, in divided doses.
- Start low; taper when stopping.

DOSAGES

- **Drug-induced EPS:** 1 mg daily, increase to 5–15 mg/day in 3–4 doses.
- **Parkinson's:** 1 mg daily, gradually to 6–10 mg/day.
- **Elderly:** lower doses; avoid if possible.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 1 h. **Duration:** 6–12 h.
- Metabolised in liver.
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 3–4 h (terminal ~33 h).

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Blocks central **muscarinic (M1)** receptors → restores dopamine–acetylcholine balance in striatum → ↓ tremor and rigidity.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Dry mouth, blurred vision, constipation.
- Urinary retention, tachycardia.
- Dizziness, nervousness.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Confusion, memory impairment, hallucinations (elderly).
- Angle-closure glaucoma.
- Euphoria and misuse.
- Worsens tardive dyskinesia.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Angle-closure glaucoma; myasthenia gravis.
- GI obstruction, paralytic ileus.
- Tardive dyskinesia; prostatic hypertrophy with retention.
- Elderly with dementia (avoid).

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Other anticholinergics (TCAs, antihistamines):** additive.
- **Donepezil:** opposing effects.
- **Alcohol:** ↑ sedation.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Assess EPS response and anticholinergic effects.
- Monitor cognition, bowel and bladder function.
- Watch for misuse (euphoria).
- Review need regularly (do not prescribe routinely with antipsychotics).

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take with food; do not stop suddenly.
- Sugar-free gum for dry mouth; increase fibre.
- Report confusion, eye pain or difficulty passing urine.
- Avoid overheating (less sweating).

KEY POINTS

- Central antimuscarinic.
- Confusion in elderly.
- Treats drug-induced parkinsonism and dystonia.
- Worsens tardive dyskinesia.

SOURCES CHECKED **[825]** Trihexyphenidyl Hydrochloride, oral (US label) **[826]** Trihexyphenidyl Hydrochloride, oral (US label, PAI Holdings)

Full references p. 432–457